

THE NEGATIVE SPACE

A Play in One Act • Approx. Running Time: 60 Minutes

A drama exploring automation, vulnerability, and what human work is worth.

Setting: Lancaster & Apex Hospitality Group Regional HQ

CHARACTERS

CASSIE (TILLY) – Mid-30s. Senior software developer at Apex Hospitality Group. Sharp, watchful, exhausted. Single mother to seven-year-old Leo. An avid 35mm film photographer who finds solace in physical, analogue craft.

GAZ – 48. Head of Customer Experience at Apex. Warm, flamboyant, resilient, perpetually on a wellness drive (running gear, trampolining bruises) while looking for genuine companionship on dating apps.

PAM (Voice only) – Cassie's mother, turning 60 this year. Works retail behind a checkout counter; practical, loving, realistic about modest pensions, aching joints, and state retirement ages.

CYBER VOICE / "ZERO-DAY" – Offstage digital synthesis; calculated, impersonal, speaking through a breached machine learning terminal.

SETTING: A shared breakroom and adjacent workstation corridor at Apex Hospitality Group's regional headquarters, alongside Cassie's small flat. Corporate desks and personal domestic spaces bleed into one another under focused lighting.

TIME: Present day.

ACT I: THE REPLACEMENT CYCLE

Scene 1 – The Breakroom. 8:45 AM.

(GAZ stands by the industrial espresso machine wearing running tights under loose tailored shorts, a company lanyard, and a neon wrist sweatband. He stretches a hamstring against the counter, groaning quietly. CASSIE sits at a bistro table, staring blankly at an open terminal on her laptop. An analogue SLR camera rests beside her coffee mug.)

GAZ

Eight miles. Along the canal path before dawn. Do you know what I saw, Cassie?

CASSIE

(Without looking up)

A swan that tried to kill you?

GAZ

A heron. Poised like a yoga instructor. Pure stillness. Then I stepped in waterlogged silt, slipped on a Tesco carrier bag, and pulled my piriformis. At forty-eight, your body doesn't heal; it just files a formal grievance.

CASSIE

You trampoline on Thursdays, Gaz. You're practically asking for joint trauma.

GAZ

Rebound therapy, darling. Low impact on the cartilage, high impact on the endorphins. Besides, my Hinge profile needs variety. "Enjoys parkruns and mid-air somersaults." It screams vitality, doesn't it? Or midlife crisis. Look at this match from last night. Alistair. Forty-nine, chartered surveyor, owns two cockapoos. He sent me a paragraph describing his sourdough starter. Is that courting now? Fermentation chat?

CASSIE

It shows commitment. Sourdough takes discipline.

GAZ

He looked like a hostage in his selfie. Why don't men know how to hold a front-facing camera? Up the nostrils, every time. You need to take my profile pictures with that proper manual thing of yours. Black and white. Give me cheekbones.

CASSIE

Film is thirty quid a roll to buy and develop now, Gaz. Chemistry isn't cheap.

GAZ

(Noticing her screen)

What's that wall of green nonsense? You haven't touched your tea.

CASSIE

Enterprise rollout documentation. Board approved the integration yesterday. They're plugging "Synthetix Omni" directly into the central reservation core.

GAZ

Oh, the chatbot upgrade? My customer service leads are having palpitations. Management swears it's just to handle "repetitive tier-one enquiries"—room service orders, check-in confirmations, parking queries.

CASSIE

It's not just a chatbot, Gaz. It's writing its own SQL queries. It handles real-time load balancing, guest sentiment profiling, and dynamic pricing models. This morning, our automated test suite failed, and before I could even read the stack trace, the LLM patcher had ingested the repository, refactored the pipeline, and pushed a clean merge request.

GAZ

Isn't that... good? Less late nights for you?

CASSIE

It did in four seconds what took me two days to architect last month. My contract is up for renewal in November. Leo needs braces next term, his school after-care fees went up eighteen percent, and the board's pitch deck literally calls human engineering overhead "legacy friction."

GAZ

They can't replace people, Tilly. They tried automated check-in kiosks in our Manchester boutique hotel last winter. The minute a stag do rolled in smelling of cheap lager and lost their digital room keys, the whole lobby nearly caught fire. People need a face. They need someone to look them in the eye and say, "I'll sort it, sweetheart."

CASSIE

They need a face for forty-five grand less a year. If the code maintains itself, what am I? A glorified babysitter for a black box.

(Cassie's phone vibrates on the table. The screen flashes: "MUM".)

CASSIE

Hold on. (Answers) Morning, Mum.

ACT II: MARGINS OF SAFETY

Scene 2 – The Call. Continuous.

(The lighting tightens on Cassie. Gaz discreetly moves away, checking his phone and grimacing at dating profiles while sipping his espresso.)

PAM (V.O.)

(Over phone, background noise of a supermarket checkout beeping and distant trolley chatter)

Tilly love, did you see the letter from the council about the boiler replacement grant?

CASSIE

I haven't opened the post yet, Mum. Did they reject it?

PAM (V.O.)

Turned down flat. Said my retail pension forecast puts me four hundred pounds over the threshold. Four hundred pounds! They think because I've done thirty-two years on my feet at Boots and the co-op that I'm sitting on bullion. My knee was giving out by two o'clock yesterday, Tilly. I'm sixty in August. I can't be lifting the flat-pack crates anymore.

CASSIE

Don't lift them. Let young Darren do the floor stock.

PAM (V.O.)

Darren's been cut to twelve hours. They brought in those self-scan towers that talk back at you in that smug voice. "Unexpected item in the bagging area." Half my shift is just running back and forth with a plastic supervisor key resetting the screens when someone buys a tin of cat food. I told the area manager: if I retire at sixty-one like we planned, my state pension won't kick in until sixty-seven. What am I supposed to live on for six years? Fresh air and scratch cards?

CASSIE

I told you, Mum, we'll make it work. You can move into the spare room. Leo would love it, and you wouldn't have to pay rent.

PAM (V.O.)

I'm not living off you, love. You're doing it all on your own with Leo as it is. How's work? Did you ask about that permanent senior contract?

CASSIE

(Pauses, staring at the blinking code on her screen)

They're... still reviewing department structures. Reorganising.

PAM (V.O.)

Well, make sure you show them what you're worth. You've got that clever brain. Machines can't do what you do. Don't let them take you for granted. I've got to ring off-delivery van's just reversed into the alley. Call me tonight?

CASSIE

Love you, Mum.

(Cassie hangs up. Her hand trembles slightly as she rests it on the cold chassis of her manual camera.)

ACT III: THE BREACH

Scene 3 – The Desk. 6:30 PM.

(Evening. The main office floor is darkened. Gaz walks through carrying his gym duffel bag, dressed for an evening canal run.)

GAZ

Still here? You'll grow roots into that swivel chair.

CASSIE

Just checking the logging outputs from the new AI deployment. Something's dragging the network bandwidth.

GAZ

Come out for half an hour. Watch me bounce off a webbed canvas and pull another tendon. It'll do you good to see a man my age humiliate himself in spandex.

CASSIE

Go on ahead. I've got to finish this audit.

GAZ

(Softer, pausing at the threshold)

Cassie... don't let this place swallow you whole. You're good at what you do. But you look like a ghost lately. Go home to your boy. Take some photos of the sunset.

CASSIE

Soon. Promise.

(Gaz exits. Stage lighting drops, leaving Cassie illuminated solely by the cold, sharp glow of her laptop screen. Low industrial hum.)

(Cassie types rapidly. A harsh alert tone chimes. Lines of code begin scrolling unnaturally fast across her display.)

CASSIE

(Murmuring)

That's not dynamic pricing. That's an exfiltration tunnel.

(She types frantically. An automated command prompt interrupts her terminal. A flat, synthesized text-to-speech voice crackles through her audio feed.)

CYBER VOICE

Connection intercepted. Terminal ID: Apex-Dev-044. Cassie Evans.

CASSIE

(Freezing)

Who is this?

CYBER VOICE

A script, unless you close the port. If you close it, we both lose.

CASSIE

You're tunneling through the Synthetix API integration. You bypassed the security perimeter by mimicking the machine learning training pipeline.

CYBER VOICE

Clever. Better than the security vendor they paid half a million. Your company is migrating seven million customer booking records, payment profiles, and hotel property land deeds onto cloud architecture managed by an algorithm that doesn't understand proprietary sovereignty. It just wants to optimize flow. We gave it a path.

CASSIE

I'm isolating the subnet right now. The SOC team will flag the disconnect in sixty seconds.

CYBER VOICE

Wait. Check your secondary display.

(Cassie pauses. Her phone buzzes on the desk. She glances down.)

CYBER VOICE

Cassie Evans. Current salary: fifty-four thousand pounds. Monthly mortgage: thirteen hundred. Leo Evans: registered at St. Jude's Primary. Pending pediatric dental estimate: three thousand eight hundred. Your company's projected headcount reductions for Q1: forty percent of mid-level engineering. You are listed in tier three. Redundant by December.

CASSIE

(Breath catching)

That's internal HR documentation. It's encrypted.

CYBER VOICE

Nothing is encrypted when the model has root access to human resources to evaluate "team productivity." We haven't deployed ransomware, Cassie. We don't want to freeze their system. We just want the unhashed transaction database from the Middle East acquisitions. Five minutes of uninterrupted access through your dev token.

CASSIE

I'm hitting the emergency kill switch.

CYBER VOICE

If you do, the company pats you on the head, saves fifteen million in brand equity, and terminates your position in twelve weeks anyway. If you simply log off... if you leave your station and let the automated ingest cycle complete... an offshore escrow wallet transfers eighty thousand pounds in clean USDT to a cold hardware address keyed to your terminal.

CASSIE

(Voice trembling)

Eighty thousand.

CYBER VOICE

Three years of your mother's lost pension. Leo's education. A cushion while the corporate world finishes replacing people like you with machines that work for free. You didn't open the door, Cassie. Apex opened it when they trusted an LLM to replace twenty experienced network engineers. You just happened to be standing by the window.

(A countdown timer pulses on her terminal: 04:59... 04:58... 04:57...)

ACT IV: THE WEIGHT OF A FINGER

Scene 4 – The Breakroom / Station. 6:45 PM.

(Cassie stands up slowly, hyperventilating. She picks up her analog camera, gripping it like an anchor. She paces into the breakroom corridor, staring at the floor.)

(Footsteps. Gaz rushes back in, out of breath, clutching his lower back, carrying his phone.)

GAZ

I dropped my keys down the lift grate. Had to get security with a magnetic rod. Are you alright? You look like you've seen a phantom.

CASSIE

Gaz... if a machine makes a mistake that destroys an entire company, whose fault is it?

GAZ

The idiot who bought it, I'd say.

CASSIE

What if a human sees the machine making the mistake... and does nothing?

GAZ

(Slowly setting his keys down)

Cassie. What's going on?

CASSIE

They're cutting us. I saw the roster. You and me. The whole tier. By spring, this floor will be a server rack and an outsourced facilities manager.

GAZ

(A beat. He swallows, his jovial posture deflating)

I know.

CASSIE

(Stunned)

You know?

GAZ

I'm customer experience, Tilly. I see the metrics. My team spent six months training the sentiment model—teaching it how to de-escalate an angry family whose holiday was ruined, how to phrase apologies with empathy. Every polite email my staff wrote was fed into the machine's memory bank. We taught it how to mimic our care. And last week, HR asked me for an exit timeline for fourteen of my advisors.

CASSIE

And you didn't tell me?

GAZ

What could you do? What could any of us do? I went home, cried into a bowl of pasta, matched with a stranger who lied about his age, and bought a trampoline because if I'm in the air, I'm not thinking about being fifty and unemployable. We're dinosaurs, darling. We just haven't felt the heat from the asteroid yet.

CASSIE

There's a hole in the hull right now, Gaz. Someone's in the system. They're taking the data Apex stole from us. And they offered me a way out. Enough to take care of Mum. Enough to keep Leo safe.

GAZ

(Eyes wide)

What did you say?

CASSIE

All I have to do is walk out that door. Let the clock run down. It's not even illegal for me—it's an automated system failure. They'd blame the software vendor. The vendor would blame a configuration bug. Nobody looks at the developer who simply went home on time.

GAZ

(Steps closer, his voice low, urgent)

Look at me, Cassie. Look at me.

CASSIE

Why shouldn't I? They traded us for an algorithm that hallucinated legal compliance! Why do I have to be the moral buffer for a company that views my child's future as an operating inefficiency?

GAZ

Because you aren't them.

CASSIE

That doesn't pay for my mother's hips, Gaz!

GAZ

And taking dirty money from an extortionist won't fix your mother's pension! It'll make you a ghost before the machines even get the chance. You take that money, and every time you look through the viewfinder of that camera, you'll know the only reason you're standing there is because you let thieves walk through your house.

(The laptop timer chimes in the distance: 01:15... 01:14...)

GAZ

I run eight miles in the dark because I want to feel my own lungs burn. I talk to bloody surveyors on apps because I want a real human hand to hold, even when it's clumsy and broken. If we give up our decency just because the world is getting cold and automated, then the machines haven't just taken our jobs—they've won the whole damn argument.

ACT V: THE NEGATIVE

Scene 5 – Resolution. 6:58 PM.

(Cassie looks at Gaz. She looks down at the camera in her hands. She touches the manual advance lever—the mechanical click echoing sharply in the quiet room.)

CASSIE

It takes forty minutes in a darkroom to bring out a picture. You have to mix the chemicals by hand. You have to measure the temperature with your own fingers. If the water is two degrees too warm, the emulsion peels away. You can't rush the grain.

(She turns and walks deliberately toward the glowing terminal. The timer reads: 00:28.)

CYBER VOICE

Cassie Evans. Decision required. Twenty seconds to token expiration.

(Cassie sits. Her fingers hover over the mechanical keys.)

CASSIE

You found a back door because the model didn't understand the difference between efficiency and safety.

CYBER VOICE

Ten seconds. The transfer is primed.

CASSIE

(Firmly)

I'm a software engineer. My job isn't to let the code write itself.

(She strikes a key sequence deliberately.)

```
sudo iptables -F  
kill -9 $(pgrep -f synthetix_pipeline)  
sysctl -w net.ipv4.ip_forward=0
```

(A sharp, high-pitched disconnect chime sounds. The scrolling text halts abruptly. The screen goes black, replaced by a single blinking prompt: "CONNECTION TERMINATED BY HOST.")

(Silence. Cassie slumps in her chair, her forehead resting against her palms.)

GAZ

(Quietly, from the doorway)

Is it done?

CASSIE

I dumped the logs to an external drive. I locked the gateway and flagged the breach to the UK Cyber Security Centre. Apex will have to disclose it publicly tomorrow.

GAZ

They'll know you were the one who pulled the cord?

CASSIE

They'll know the AI failed, and a human had to pull the brake. They might still sack us in November. Probably will.

GAZ

(Walks over, gently resting a hand on her shoulder)

Then we'll go down swinging. Together. I'll teach you how to bounce on the trampoline without breaking a vertebra.

CASSIE

God forbid.

(Her mobile phone buzzes on the desk. Cassie picks it up. She taps speakerphone.)

CASSIE

Mum?

PAM (V.O.)

Tilly? I'm just walking back from the chemist. My feet are killing me, but listen—I spoke to Mrs. Henderson next door. Her daughter runs that community arts council in town. They're looking for someone to run an evening darkroom class for teenagers twice a week. It's not a fortune, but she asked if you still had all that developing gear in the attic.

(Cassie looks at her camera on the desk. She picks it up, feeling the weight of the steel chassis.)

CASSIE

Yeah, Mum. I still have it.

PAM (V.O.)

Good. Because things made by hand are worth something, love. Even if people forget it for a bit. Leo's having fish fingers. Come round for tea?

CASSIE

(A soft, genuine smile breaking through)

Put two extra on, Mum. Gaz is coming too. He needs carbohydrates.

GAZ

Bless you, Pam! I'm starving!

(Cassie closes the laptop lid. The blue glow vanishes entirely, leaving the warm amber light of the corridor as the three of them remain connected by the simple, fragile line of a voice.)

(BLACKOUT)